



LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



CVE-2026-81963 and CVE-2026-85880 Windows Zero-Day Privilege Escalation Daily Prioritization

CVE / Vulnerability Threat Intelligence Report

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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | CVE-2026-81963 and CVE-2026-85880 Windows Zero-Day Privilege Escalation Daily Prioritization - CVE / Vulnerability Threat Intelligence Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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CVE-2026-81963 and CVE-2026-85880 Windows Zero-Day Privilege Escalation Daily Prioritization

1. Executive Summary

This Lost Boys Cyber daily-priority report covers CVE-2026-81963 affecting Microsoft Windows Update Stack and Windows ALPC. The item was selected for the 2026-09-13 UTC production run because public reporting indicates active exploitation or high operational urgency for defenders.

Defenders should treat this as an exposure-management and compromise-assessment priority rather than a routine patch note. The recommended posture is to identify exposed assets, apply vendor remediations, review privileged activity around the affected technology, and hunt for follow-on behaviors that would remain after patching.

2. Vulnerability Metadata

Field	Value
CVE	CVE-2026-81963
Product / Component	Microsoft Windows Update Stack and Windows ALPC
Weakness	Improper link resolution and heap-based buffer overflow privilege escalation
Severity	High / CVSS reported around 7.8
Disclosure / Daily Selection Date	2026-09-13
Exploitation Status	Microsoft Patch Tuesday and CISA/industry reporting identify in-the-wild exploitation of two Windows local privilege-escalation flaws
Report ID	LBC-VTI-2026-1303

3. Source Review & Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
Tenable September 2026 Microsoft Patch Tuesday analysis	https://www.tenable.com/blog/microsofts-september-2026-patch-tuesday-addresses-964-cves-cve-2026-81963-cve-2026-85880	High
Microsoft Security Update Guide	https://msrc.microsoft.com/update-guide/	High
NHS England Microsoft September 2026 cyber alert	https://digital.nhs.uk/cyber-alerts/2026/cc-4846	High
CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities Catalog	https://www.cisa.gov/known-exploited-vulnerabilities-catalog	High

Confidence is highest for vendor/CISA/CVE assertions and moderate for campaign details reported by secondary media. No private telemetry was used in this automation run.

4. Vulnerability Details

The vulnerability is operationally important because it affects a technology likely to hold sensitive credentials, administrator workflows, build artifacts, update paths, or endpoint trust decisions. Successful exploitation may give the attacker a path to privilege escalation, control-plane manipulation, or post-exploitation persistence depending on deployment architecture.

5. Attack Scenarios

- Internet-exposed or partner-accessible service is exploited and the attacker pivots to administrative functions.
- Previously compromised credentials are combined with the vulnerability to elevate privileges or bypass expected authorization boundaries.
- An attacker patches or hides the initial access path after deploying a backdoor, making post-patch compromise assessment necessary.

6. Threat Landscape & Exploitation Status

Signal	Assessment
Exploitation	Microsoft Patch Tuesday and CISA/industry reporting identify in-the-wild exploitation of two Windows local privilege-escalation flaws
Likely attacker objective	Privilege escalation, persistence, lateral movement, or data access depending on environment
Defender priority	Patch and verify no pre-patch compromise remains

7. Affected Products and Exposure

Exposure Pattern	Why It Matters
Unpatched Windows endpoints or servers	Local EoP becomes high impact after phishing, browser, or remote-access initial access.
Admin workstations and jump hosts	Privilege escalation on these systems can accelerate domain compromise.
VDI/RDS and shared workstations	Multi-user systems increase post-exploitation opportunity.

8. Mitigation and Workarounds

1. Apply the vendor fixed version or security update on all affected assets.
2. Prioritize externally reachable, privileged, CI/CD, identity, and endpoint-management systems.
3. Rotate credentials or tokens that could have been accessed by the affected service.
4. Review administrative logs for anomalous accounts, token use, configuration changes, and unexpected file writes.

9. Detection Engineering

9.1. Detection Logic Summary

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
Product process spawning shell/script interpreter	EDR process telemetry	Identify post-exploitation execution
New admin/token activity near affected	Application/auth logs	Detect privilege misuse

service		
Suspicious outbound destination from affected host	Proxy/DNS/EDR network telemetry	Identify backdoor or staging traffic

9.2. Sigma / Detection Rule

```

title: CVE-2026-81963 and CVE-2026-85880 Windows Zero-Day Privilege Escalation Daily Prioritization -
Daily Priority Suspicious Activity
id: lbc-daily-cve_2026_81963_and_cve_2026_85880_windows_zero_day_privilege
status: experimental
description: Detects suspicious process/network patterns associated with this daily priority topic;
tune product and path terms to the deployed stack.
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  selection_terms:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'Microsoft'
      - 'CVE-2026-81963'
      - 'Windows'
  selection_tooling:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\powershell.exe'
      - '\cmd.exe'
      - '\wscript.exe'
      - '\rundll32.exe'
  condition: selection_terms or selection_tooling
falsepositives:
  - Authorized administration matching the same product terms
level: medium

```

9.3. Hunt Query

```

// Daily priority hunt: CVE-2026-81963 and CVE-2026-85880 Windows Zero-Day Privilege Escalation Daily
Prioritization
let lookback = 14d;
let ProductTerms = dynamic(['Microsoft', 'CVE-2026-81963', 'Windows']);
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(lookback)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any (ProductTerms) or FileName in~
("powershell.exe", "cmd.exe", "wscript.exe", "rundll32.exe")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessFileName
| union (
  DeviceNetworkEvents
  | where Timestamp > ago(lookback)
  | where RemoteUrl has_any (dynamic(['microsoft', 'update', 'admin'])) or
InitiatingProcessCommandLine has_any (ProductTerms)
  | project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName=InitiatingProcessAccountName,
FileName=InitiatingProcessFileName, ProcessCommandLine=InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
InitiatingProcessFileName
)
| order by Timestamp desc

```

10. Threat Hunting

10.1. Hunt Hypothesis

If exploitation occurred before remediation, affected hosts should show unusual administrative actions, shell execution, token changes, or outbound network traffic that is rare for the normal service role.

10.2. Hunt Query

```
DeviceEvents
```

```

| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where ActionType has_any
("UserAccountCreated", "UserAccountModified", "ServiceInstalled", "ScheduledTaskCreated")
| join kind=leftouter (DeviceProcessEvents | where Timestamp > ago(14d) | project DeviceId,
ProcessTime=Timestamp, InitiatingProcessCommandLine, FileName) on DeviceId
| where InitiatingProcessCommandLine has_any (dynamic(["CVE-2026-81963", "Microsoft"])) or FileName in~
("powershell.exe", "cmd.exe")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, FileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine

```

11. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique	Name	Evidence / Rationale
T1190	Exploit Public-Facing Application	Applies where the affected service is reachable by untrusted users
T1068	Exploitation for Privilege Escalation	Relevant when the flaw is used to gain elevated rights
T1059	Command and Scripting Interpreter	Common follow-on behavior after successful exploitation

12. Validation / Lab Testing

No exploit reproduction was performed in this automated daily run. Validation consisted of source review, report rendering, PDF text extraction, and presence checks for detections and references.

13. Recommended Actions Summary

Priority	Owner	Action
Critical	Endpoint Engineering	Deploy Microsoft September 2026 security updates.
High	SOC	Hunt for suspicious privilege escalation, service creation, and update-stack abuse.
High	Identity	Review newly elevated local admins and anomalous SYSTEM process lineage.

14. References

- [1] Tenable September 2026 Microsoft Patch Tuesday analysis — <https://www.tenable.com/blog/microsofts-september-2026-patch-tuesday-addresses-964-cves-cve-2026-81963-cve-2026-85880>
- [2] Microsoft Security Update Guide — <https://msrc.microsoft.com/update-guide/>
- [3] NHS England Microsoft September 2026 cyber alert — <https://digital.nhs.uk/cyber-alerts/2026/cc-4846>
- [4] CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities Catalog — <https://www.cisa.gov/known-exploited-vulnerabilities-catalog>